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country's record of managing its natural resources in the first 50 years of Independence. The report card produced was unflattering. India had done a very poor job of using its natural resources in an efficient manner. This was not only harmful in biophysical terms, but also had serious economic costs associated with degradation and damage to the country's natural resources. The estimate of costs from environmental pollution and depletion or degradation of key natural resources amounted to over 10 per cent of the GDP. It also established that 11 to 26 per cent of the country's agricultural output was being lost on account of soil erosion. Other findings indicated serious problems with air pollution and pollution of all the water bodies in the country, as a result of which India's rivers are dead and cannot support any form of life. Additionally, there were serious threats of extinction for a number of species. While the spread of deforestation had been suc-

cessfully arrested, in several areas what constitutes forest cover is so degraded that the low density of trees could hardly qualify as forest land. This detailed study came up with projections up to 2047 when India would have completed 100 years as an independent nation. On a business-as-usual basis, the projections for 2047 painted a nightmarish scenario. Since 1997 some progress has taken place, and an assessment of the current situation presents mixed results, but generally shows continuing neglect of policies and actions that would correct the long-term costs resulting from neglect of our natural resources.

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Today, there is growing pressure from the international community to have India accept some restrictions on the growth of its emissions of greenhouse gases as part of the global effort to tackle climate change.

Quite rightly, India has resisted these efforts, because the principle of "common but differentiated responsibility", enshrined in the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change adopted glob-

Change of state: India faces an opportunity in improving the use of natural resources in the economy